

Psalms 131

A Childlike Quietness of Soul

Like a weaned child with his mother, so is my soul weaned within me

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *LORD, my heart is not haughty, nor mine eyes lofty: neither do I exercise myself in great matters, or in things too high for me.*
2 *Surely I have behaved and quieted myself, as a child that is weaned of his mother: my soul is even as a weaned child.*
3 *Let Israel hope in the LORD from henceforth and for ever.*

2 • CONTEXT

Psalm 131 is one of the shortest Songs of Ascents, sung by pilgrims climbing toward Jerusalem, and it reads like a settled exhale after the anguished cry of Psalm 130. Attributed to David, it renounces ambition and speculation in favor of a deliberately small, quiet posture before God. Henry reads it as a rare biblical self-portrait of humility successfully attained, not merely urged; MacArthur-style notes highlight the weaned-child image as the psalm's emotional center—contentment that no longer clamors, having learned that nearness to a caregiver matters more than getting one's way.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

David denies a haughty heart, a proud look, or meddling in matters too great and high for him—an explicit renunciation of ambition, status-seeking, and the compulsion to have an opinion on every mystery. In their place he offers a single image: his soul is quieted and calmed like a weaned child resting against its mother, no longer crying for milk, content simply to be held.

Verse 3

The private posture becomes a public exhortation: let Israel hope in the Lord, now and forever. The individual's hard-won quietness is offered as a pattern for the whole worshiping community, not kept as a private accomplishment.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Spiritual maturity, this psalm suggests, is measured less by how much a person understands or controls and more by how settled the soul becomes in simple dependence on God. The weaned child no longer fusses for immediate satisfaction because it has learned to trust the relationship itself; David commends that same demotion of anxious striving in favor of quiet, hope-filled rest.

Application for life today.

Notice where you are currently straining after matters 'too high' for you—outcomes, explanations, or control that are not actually yours to secure—and consider laying that reaching down deliberately before God. Let the weaned-child image reshape your prayer life: aim less at getting God to move on your schedule and more at resting contentedly in His presence regardless of the immediate answer. Practice offering this quietness publicly, as David does in verse 3, by modeling calm hope for others rather than only pursuing it privately.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What matter 'too great and too high' for you are you currently straining to understand or control, and what would it look like to set it down?

2. How does the image of a weaned child—content rather than clamoring—describe or challenge the current state of your soul before God?

3. In what relationship or community could your own settled hope in God, like David's in verse 3, become an encouragement to others?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).